

Monday, 31 August 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Showers

22° 15°

BIRMINGHAM

Rain

18° 14°

MANCHESTER

Light drizzle

18° 14°

GLASGOW

Overcast

18° 14°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

1

Burnham gets the early prison release changes he wanted - but at what cost?.

The prime minister says he will keep hundreds more criminals behind bars but doing so requires complex changes.

POLITICS · UK

2

Church leads tributes for man killed at festival.

Robert Guanco, 41, was a pastor at Jesus the Living Water Church in Eastbourne, East Sussex.

UK · NEWS

3

Sons of officer who died in A66 crash lead out Man Utd as mascots.

The sons of PC Matthew Blades led Manchester United out at Old Trafford for Sunday's Premier League game with Ipswich.

UK · NEWS

4

Dementia patient's deportation from Sweden delayed.

George Mason, originally from Hinckley in Leicestershire, is facing deportation from Sweden.

UK · NEWS

5

Two murder arrests after balcony fall man dies.

A man who fell from a balcony died on Saturday night after he was critically injured, police say.

UK · NEWS

02 – SHOWBIZ

What's coming up

- 1 Dolly Parton's dad couldn't read - it inspired her to send books to millions of children.**
Families across the globe share how free books from Parton's Imagination Library helped their children.
SHOWBIZ · UK
- 2 Selena Gomez pushes back against 'frivolous' fraud claims.**
Selena Gomez's lawyer says the fraud case is "absurd" - but it is far from unusual for celebrity family business relationships to go wrong.
SHOWBIZ · UK
- 3 BBC director-general says he was not aware of 'severity' of cuts needed.**
Matt Brittin succeeded Tim Davie as boss of the BBC in May.
SHOWBIZ · UK
- 4 Dolly Parton's life story through six iconic songs.**
A legendary singer-songwriter, her music covered themes around love, loss, female empowerment and spirituality.
SHOWBIZ · UK
- 5 'If you want the rainbow, you gotta put up with the rain': The wit and wisdom of Dolly Parton.**
The much-loved country singer-songwriter in her own words, following her death aged 80.
SHOWBIZ · UK

On the schedule

- 1 How did Rashford do on return to Man Utd XI? Player ratings.**
How Manchester United and Ipswich Town's players rated following their Premier League match.
SPORT · UK
- 2 'His best Test for a year' - England-Pakistan player ratings.**
Who produced their best Test performance in 12 months? Which batter is building a case to test the selectors?
Player ratings from England's win over Pakistan.
SPORT · UK
- 3 Joao Pedro and debutant Yalcouye star - Chelsea v Brighton player ratings.**
Here's how the players rated as Chelsea and Brighton met in the Premier League on Sunday.
SPORT · UK
- 4 Why Man Utd goal was allowed to stand - despite Maguire 'handball'.**
The handball law often serves to confuse supporters - and it reared its head again as Harry Maguire celebrated putting Manchester United in front against Ipswich Town.
SPORT · UK
- 5 Tech trouble leaves Chelsea game ref without comms.**
When referee Michael Oliver emerged for the second half at Stamford Bridge on Sunday something important was missing - his communications pack.
SPORT · UK

Quick hits

- 1 Scientists have found that looking at photos of cute animals can boost productivity at work.**
A study suggests that even a quick glance at a picture of a puppy or a kitten can improve focus and motor skills, making tasks feel less daunting.
- 2 The delightful trend of 'library book blind dates' is encouraging people to discover new authors and genres.**
Libraries are wrapping books in paper with just a few intriguing keywords, inviting readers to choose a book based purely on its mystery rather than its cover.
- 3 More people are embracing the simple joy of 'writing a letter' to a friend or family member.**
In a world of instant messages, the thoughtful act of putting pen to paper and sending a handwritten note is experiencing a charming revival as a meaningful connection.
- 4 Research indicates that spending time near a 'blue space', like a river or a lake, can significantly improve mood and well-being.**
The calming presence of water is believed to reduce stress and promote feelings of tranquility, even for short periods.
- 5 A growing number of individuals are finding satisfaction in 'mending clothes' rather than buying new ones.**
This sustainable trend not only extends the life of favourite garments but also offers a creative and mindful hobby, often with charming visible repairs.
- 6 The unexpected pleasure of 'foraging for wild berries and mushrooms' is becoming a popular outdoor activity.**
Guided walks are helping people safely identify edible delights in local woodlands, connecting them with nature and providing delicious, fresh produce.
- 7 Home bakers are experimenting with 'ancient grain recipes', bringing a touch of history to their kitchens.**
From spelt to einkorn, these grains are being rediscovered for their unique flavours and textures, offering a wholesome alternative to conventional flour.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to quickly judge if a new book will be good, without actually reading more than the first paragraph?

ANSWER: THEY SNIFF THE PAGES, ESPECIALLY IF IT'S A NEW PAPERBACK!

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before settling down to enjoy a lovely, warm piece of cake, especially if it's homemade. What is it?

ANSWER: THEY MUST HAVE A PERFECTLY CLEAN FORK, EVEN IF IT MEANS WASHING ONE SPECIFICALLY FOR THE OCCASION!

TALK TOPIC

- You know how sometimes you discover a 'quirky local tradition' or a fun community event that's been going on for years, and it just makes you smile?

What are some of the charmingly unusual local traditions or events that happen where you live, and what makes them so special?

- We all have those 'little rituals' or comforting routines we do at home to wind down at the end of a busy day, don't we?

What's your favourite evening ritual to help you relax and switch off, even if it's something really simple?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** Did you know that a group of owls is called a 'parliament'?

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Did you know that honeybees communicate the location of new flower patches by doing a special dance that involves 'singing' a little tune?

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£5.2 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£5.2 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The world's first ever postage stamp, the 'Penny Black', was issued in the UK in 1840.
- A 'fluffle' is the charming collective noun for a group of rabbits.
- The Great Fire of London in 1666 actually helped to eradicate the Black Death in the city.
- Bumblebees can fly higher than Mount Everest, if conditions are right.
- The first recorded game of golf was played in Scotland in the 15th century.
- Sea otters hold hands when they sleep so they don't drift away from each other.
- The shortest war in history was between Britain and Zanzibar in 1896, lasting only 38 minutes.
- A 'murder' is the collective noun for a group of crows.

On this day

Day 243 of the year, 122 days left in 2026. Today Baloch-Pakhtun Unity Day (Balochs and Pashtuns, International observance); Christian feast day: Aidan of Lindisfarne; Christian feast day: Aristides of Athens; Christian feast day: Cuthburh. Star sign Virgo, birthstone Peridot.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1971 — Kirstie Allsopp, British TV presenter
- 1979 — Yara Martinez, Puerto Rican-American actress
- 1998 — BossMan Dlow, American rapper
- 1967 — Gene Hoglan, American drummer
- 1960 — Chris Whitley, American singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 2005)
- 1962 — Dee Bradley Baker, American voice actor
- 1971 — Pádraig Harrington, Irish golfer
- 1977 — Ian Harte, Irish footballer

THE DAY TODAY

- 2025 — An earthquake in eastern Afghanistan kills over 1400 people.
- 1996 — Saddam Hussein's troops seize Irbil after the Kurdish Masoud Barzani appealed for help to defeat his Kurdish rival PUK.
- 1993 — Russia completes removing its troops from Lithuania.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1986 — Aeroméxico Flight 498 collides with a Piper PA-28 Cherokee over Cerritos, California, killing 67 in the air and 15 on the ground.
- 1994 — Russia completes removing its troops from Estonia.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1993 — Russia completes removing its troops from Lithuania.
- 1988 — Delta Air Lines Flight 1141 crashes during takeoff from Dallas/Fort Worth International Airport, killing 14.

- 2002 — Typhoon Rusa, the most powerful typhoon to hit South Korea in 43 years, makes landfall, killing at least 236 people.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 244 of the year, 121 days left in 2026. Today Feast of Creation (Christianity); Christian feast day: Constantius (Costanzo) of Aquino; Christian feast day: David Pendleton Oakerhater (Anglican Communion); Christian feast day: Giles. Star sign Virgo, birthstone Sapphire.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1973 — Simon Shaw, English rugby player
- 1933 — Conway Twitty, American singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 1993)
- 1976 — Clare Connor, English cricketer
- 1991 — Rhys Bennett, English footballer
- 1957 — Gloria Estefan, Cuban-American singer-songwriter and actress
- 1996 — Zendaya, American actress and singer
- 1952 — Michael Masee, American actor (died 2016)
- 1984 — Joe Trohman, American singer-songwriter, guitarist and producer

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1864 — American Civil War: The Battle of Jonesborough, alongside the overall Atlanta campaign, culminates in a Union victory for General William T. Sherman as Confederate General John Bell Hood orders the evacuation of Atlanta.
- 1974 — The SR-71 Blackbird sets (and holds) the record for flying from New York to London in the time of one hour, 54 minutes and 56.4 seconds at a speed of 1,435.587 miles per hour (2,310.353 km/h).
- 1897 — The Tremont Street Subway in Boston opens, becoming the first underground rapid transit system in North America.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1880 — The army of Mohammad Ayub Khan is routed by the British at the Battle of Kandahar, ending the Second Anglo-Afghan War.
- 1873 — Cetshwayo ascends to the throne as king of the Zulu nation following the death of his father Mpande.

10 — FORWARD PLANNING • FILM

Coming to cinemas

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
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FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
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FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
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FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)
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OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
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FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)
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11 — FORWARD PLANNING • SPORT

On the sporting calendar